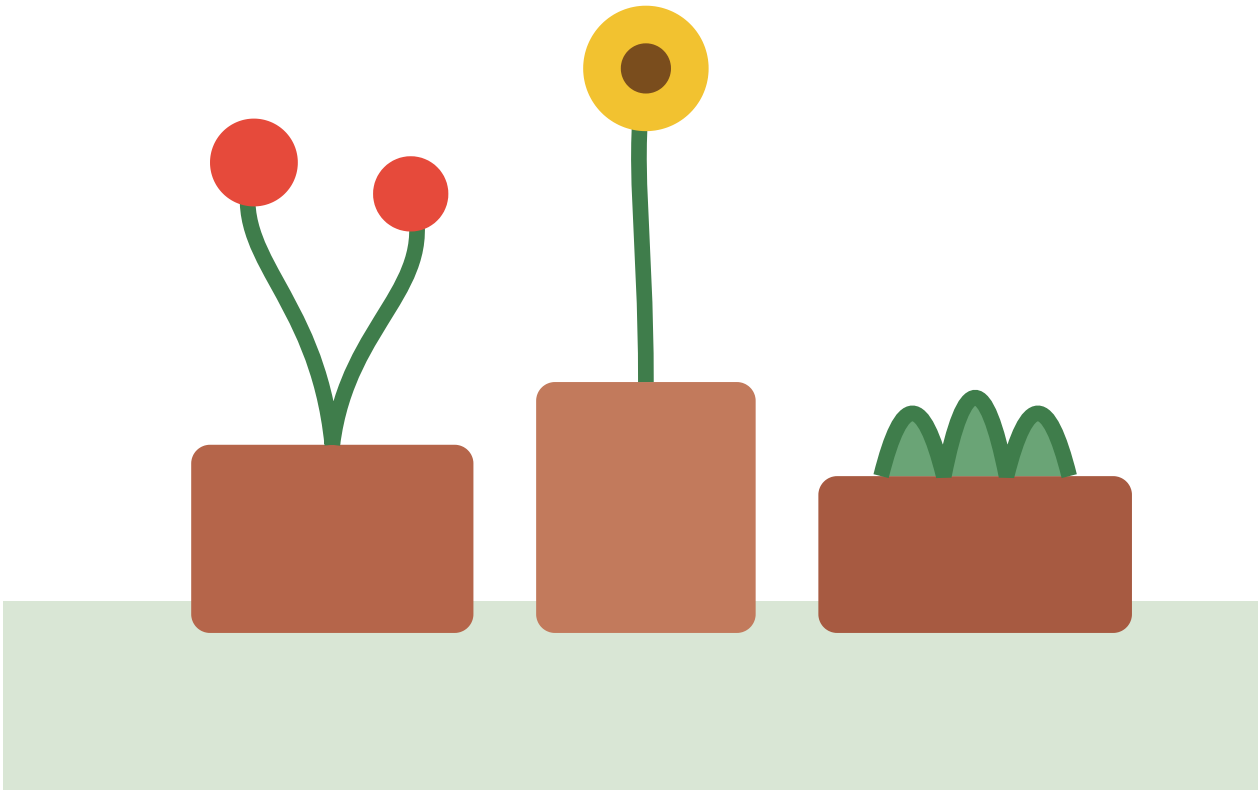
A FIELD GUIDE

Pocket Gardens

Growing food and flowers on a balcony, a windowsill or a step



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This guide is meant to be read in any order. Chapters 2 to 4 are the foundations: if a plant fails, the reason is almost always light, soil or water. Chapter 5 is the shopping list, and chapter 7 is for the day a leaf turns yellow.

1. Why a pocket garden

A pocket garden is any growing space small enough to reach from where you stand: a railing box, three pots on a step, a herb tray on the kitchen sill. It will not feed a family, and it does not need to. What it gives is closer to a habit than a harvest: a reason to look outside every morning, a handful of basil that tastes like basil, and the slow satisfaction of a tomato that ripens because you paid attention.

Small spaces have real advantages. Pests are easy to spot when every leaf is at eye level. Watering takes a minute. Mistakes cost the price of a seed packet. And because containers can be moved, a pocket garden can follow the sun across a balcony through the seasons in a way that a bed in the ground never can.

What you need to begin

- One container with a drainage hole, at least 20 cm deep.
- A bag of potting mix (not garden soil, see chapter 3).
- A watering can with a fine rose, or a bottle with holes in the cap.
- Two or three plants from the forgiving list in chapter 5.

> **Start smaller than you think.** Three healthy pots teach more than twelve struggling ones. Add a container each month once the first ones are thriving.

Throughout the guide, quantities are given for a single 30 cm pot unless stated otherwise. A 30 cm pot holds about 12 litres of mix, enough for one tomato, three lettuces or a generous clump of herbs.

2. Reading your light

Light is the one thing you cannot buy at the garden centre, so measure it before choosing plants. Spend a clear day noting when direct sun reaches the spot where your pots will stand, and when it leaves. Count only direct sun: bright shade, however pleasant, does not ripen fruit.

Direct sun per day	What it is called	What grows well
6 hours or more	Full sun	Tomatoes, peppers, beans, most herbs, marigolds
3 to 6 hours	Part sun	Lettuce, chard, peas, strawberries, parsley
Under 3 hours	Shade	Mint, chives, ferns, begonias, microgreens

Orientation

In the southern hemisphere a north-facing balcony gets the most sun; in the northern hemisphere, a south-facing one. East light is gentle and cool, good for leafy greens. West light arrives in the hottest part of the day and can scorch delicate leaves in summer, though fruiting plants enjoy it.

Reflections and obstacles

A white wall behind your pots can add an hour of usable light; a glass railing can focus heat. Upper floors often get more light than ground floors but also more wind, which dries pots quickly. Note the shadow of any neighbouring building in winter, when the sun is low: a spot that is sunny in January may be shaded in June, and the other way around.

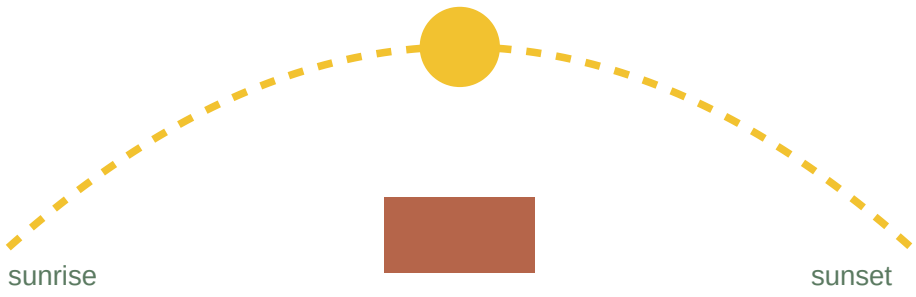


Figure 1. Track the sun's path across your space once in summer and once in winter.

3. Containers and soil

Almost anything that holds soil and drains water can be a container: terracotta, glazed ceramic, wooden crates lined with burlap, fabric grow bags, even a reused paint tin with holes punched in the bottom. What matters is volume and drainage. Roots that sit in water rot within days, and small pots dry out within hours on a hot afternoon.

Choosing a size

Bigger is easier. A large pot holds more water, keeps a steadier temperature and gives roots room to explore. As a rule of thumb, leafy herbs need 15 cm of depth, salad greens 20 cm, and fruiting plants such as tomatoes or peppers at least 30 cm.

Why not garden soil

Soil dug from the ground compacts in a pot, squeezing out the air that roots need, and may carry weed seeds and disease. Use a potting mix designed for containers: light, springy and quick to drain. A good home blend is two parts compost, one part coconut coir and one part perlite or coarse sand.

> **The squeeze test.** Grab a handful of moist mix and squeeze. It should hold together, then crumble when poked. If it drips, it is too wet; if it will not hold a shape, add compost.

Feeding

Potting mix runs out of nutrients after about six weeks, because every watering washes some away. From then on, feed fruiting plants every two weeks with a liquid fertiliser at half the strength on the label, and leafy plants once a month. Too much feed gives lush leaves and no fruit.

4. Watering without drowning

More container plants die of too much water than too little. The goal is not a schedule but a habit: check first, then water deeply, then let the top of the mix dry before watering again.

The finger test

Push a finger into the mix up to the second knuckle. If it feels dry at the tip, water until it runs from the drainage hole. If it feels cool and damp, wait a day. Lifting the pot works too: a dry pot is surprisingly light.

Season	Small pot (15 cm)	Large pot (30 cm)
Summer, full sun	Daily, sometimes twice	Every 1 to 2 days
Spring and autumn	Every 2 to 3 days	Every 3 to 4 days
Winter	Weekly	Every 10 days or less

Mornings are best

Water in the morning so plants start the day full and leaves dry before night, when damp foliage invites mildew. In a heatwave, a second evening drink at the base of the plant is fine. Avoid splashing leaves of tomatoes and squash.

Going away

For a weekend, group pots together in the shade and stand them in trays with a centimetre of water. For a longer trip, a bottle pushed neck-down into the mix, or a wick of cotton string running from a bucket into each pot, keeps roots moist for a week.

5. Twelve plants that forgive you

These twelve tolerate the occasional missed watering, small pots and imperfect light. They are grouped by how much sun they need; see chapter 2 to read your own.

Plant	Sun	Pot depth	From sowing to harvest	Notes
Cherry tomato	Full	30 cm	10 to 12 weeks	Choose a dwarf or "patio" variety; stake early
Chilli pepper	Full	25 cm	12 to 14 weeks	Likes heat; keeps for years indoors in winter
Dwarf bean	Full	20 cm	8 weeks	Pick often and it keeps producing
Basil	Full	15 cm	6 weeks	Pinch the tips so it branches; never let it flower
Thyme	Full	15 cm	Perennial	Thrives on neglect and poor soil
Marigold	Full	15 cm	8 weeks	Edible petals; keeps aphids off tomatoes
Lettuce	Part	20 cm	5 weeks	Cut outer leaves and it regrows
Chard	Part	25 cm	7 weeks	Colourful stems; harvests for months
Strawberry	Part	20 cm	Perennial	Hanging pots keep fruit off the ground
Parsley	Part	20 cm	10 weeks	Slow to sprout; soak the seed overnight
Mint	Shade	20 cm	Perennial	Give it its own pot: it takes over
Chives	Shade	15 cm	Perennial	Purple flowers are edible too

> **Companions.** Basil and marigold planted at the foot of a tomato share its pot happily and seem to discourage pests. Keep mint alone.

6. A year on the balcony

Spring

Refresh the top third of every pot with new mix and compost. Sow lettuce, peas and herbs as soon as nights stay above 8 °C, and start tomatoes and peppers indoors on a bright sill six weeks before that.

Summer

This is the season of watering and picking. Harvest little and often: beans, herbs and lettuce all produce more when cut. Move leafy greens into afternoon shade when the heat arrives, and feed fruiting plants every two weeks.

Autumn

Sow a second round of lettuce and spinach, which prefer cool days. Pick the last green tomatoes and let them ripen on a windowsill. Collect seed from marigolds and beans for next year, and dry them in a paper envelope.

Winter

Bring chillies and tender herbs indoors to the brightest window. Group hardy pots against a wall, where it is warmest, and water sparingly. Use the quiet months to clean pots, sharpen scissors and plan: a pocket garden's best tool is a notebook.

7. When things go wrong

What you see	Likely cause	What to do
Yellow lower leaves	Overwatering, or hungry plant	Let the mix dry; feed at half strength
Wilting in the afternoon, fine by morning	Heat stress	Move to afternoon shade; mulch the surface
Wilting that does not recover	Root rot	Check drainage; repot in fresh dry mix
Tall, pale, floppy stems	Too little light	Move to a sunnier spot; choose shade plants
Sticky leaves, tiny green insects	Aphids	Spray off with water; wipe with soapy cloth
White powder on leaves	Powdery mildew	Remove affected leaves; water at the base
Flowers but no fruit	No pollinators, or too much feed	Shake flowering stems gently each morning

Most problems in a pocket garden are caught early simply because the garden is small enough to see in a glance. Make a habit of a short morning walk past every pot with a cup of something warm: it is the best pest control there is.

8. Notes and further reading

Seasons in this guide are given for temperate climates. In the tropics, think in wet and dry seasons instead, and favour plants that tolerate heat, such as chillies, basil and okra.

The interactive examples that accompany this guide, including a document viewer that can highlight and annotate it, are part of m3ui.dev, a Material Design 3 component library for Vue.

Glossary

- **Coir**: fibre from coconut husks, used to lighten potting mix.
- **Hardening off**: getting seedlings used to outdoor conditions over a week.
- **Mulch**: a layer on the soil surface (straw, bark, gravel) that keeps moisture in.
- **Perlite**: light volcanic granules that improve drainage.
- **Pinching out**: removing a stem's growing tip so the plant branches.

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